The Messianic Bible Buyer’s Guide

What the translations actually do differently — notes from a Bible translator (Tov Rose)

NMV, TLV, and CJB compared side by side:
real verse samples, verified editions and prices, and a decision guide.

By Tov Rose, translator of the New Messianic Version (NMV) · October 2026

$14 one-time

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About the author

Full disclosure, up front: Tov Rose translated one of the Bibles compared in this guide. That is exactly why he can show you what the translators are doing — and why the independent facts are sourced to the publishers’ own pages. Prices and editions verified October 17, 2026.

Full disclosure, up front: I translated one of the Bibles compared in this guide. That is exactly why I can show you what the translators are doing — and it is also why you should weigh my NMV section against the independent facts, which I have sourced to the publishers' own pages. Prices and editions verified October 17, 2026. Check the publishers' sites for current details.

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1. Why "Messianic" translations exist at all

Open almost any standard English Bible to Exodus 3:14. God tells Moses His name — I AM — and then translators spend the rest of the Old Testament replacing it: *LORD* in small caps, *GOD* in small caps. Titles where the Hebrew has a person. Four hundred years of tradition, and you can read the Bible cover to cover and never once encounter the name God gave Himself.

Messianic translations are all responses to that problem, plus one more: the New Testament was written by Jews, about a Jewish Messiah, quoting a Hebrew

Bible. Every Messianic translation tries to let English readers see that. They disagree — sometimes sharply — on how.

The four things they change, in some combination:

- **Names.** Jesus → Yeshua. Christ → Messiah/Moshiach. God → Elohim/Elōhīm. Mary → Miriam. James → Ya'akov.
- **The Name.** What to do with YHWH: LORD (traditional), ADONAI, Yehovah, Yahweh, or the Hebrew letters themselves.
- **Book order.** The Christian Old Testament reorders the Hebrew Bible. Some Messianic translations restore the Tanakh order: Torah, Nevi'im (Prophets), Ketuvim (Writings).
- **Reading level and lens.** Some translate sentence by sentence from the Hebrew/Greek; others paraphrase for readability; one in this guide (the NMV) adds bracketed identifications so you can see *who* is speaking.

No translation is neutral. Every one makes choices. This guide shows you the choices, so you can pick the one whose choices match what you want.

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2. The four Bibles in this guide

Full name

- **NMV:** New Messianic Version
- **TLV:** Tree of Life Version
- **CJB:** Complete Jewish Bible

Translator

- **NMV:** Tov Rose (single translator)
- **TLV:** 32 scholars (team)
- **CJB:** Dr. David H. Stern (single translator)

Complete Bible published

- **NMV:** Print editions on Amazon; free on YouVersion (nmvbible.org)
- **TLV:** Project began May 2008 (tlvbiblesociety.org)
- **CJB:** 1998, Jewish New Testament Publications, Clarksville MD

Old Testament basis

- **NMV:** New translation
- **TLV:** New translation; Greek sentence structure "restored to Hebrew sentence structure" (publisher)
- **CJB:** Paraphrase/revision of the 1917 Jewish Publication Society Tanakh

New Testament basis

- **NMV:** New translation
- **TLV:** New translation
- **CJB:** Stern's original Jewish New Testament (1989), from the ancient Greek

Name of God

- **NMV:** Rendered with identifications: Yehōvah, Adōnai, Elōhīm, with bracketed notes on who is speaking
- **TLV:** "Messiah Yeshua" for "Jesus Christ"; Hebrew renderings throughout
- **CJB:** ADONAI and Hebrew names; "Jewish English" with Hebrew and Yiddish expressions

Book order

- **NMV:** Tanakh order (Torah, Nevi'im, Ketuvim)
- **TLV:** "Jewish book order" for the Old Testament (publisher)
- **CJB:** Hebrew book order for the Tanakh

Best for

- **NMV:** Readers who want to see the Messiah in the Tanakh the way the apostles read it
- **TLV:** Families; readers who want a committee translation with a read-aloud feel
- **CJB:** Students who want one scholar's unified voice plus the companion commentary

A note on "Sacred Name" Bibles: several smaller publishers produce Sacred Name editions that restore Hebrew forms (Yahweh, Yahshua) aggressively. There is no single standard Sacred Name edition and quality varies widely by publisher — always read the publisher's sample text before buying. They are not compared verse-by-verse here.

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3. The NMV: what it does differently

The New Messianic Version was translated by Tov Rose, author of more than 30 books, ARRM Cares Award recipient (2018), APSE Certified (2017–2020), with live TV, radio, and podcast interviews on local, national, and international networks including TBN, ABC, and CBS. (nmvbible.org)

The core idea. In the NMV, the "names" of God are treated as what they functionally are in the text: titles, descriptions, offices, and duties — each assigned to a specific member of the Godhead. The Father enthroned. The Son appearing, speaking, and being seen. The Spirit moving. The translation marks this passage by passage, which is why readers keep finding Jesus all through the Old Testament. (nmvbible.org: "the 'names' aren't names — they're how you know WHO is speaking")

What that looks like on the page (quoted verbatim from the NMV 2.0.1 manuscript):

- Genesis 1:1 — "[All of that] Beginning [stuff] God-Elōhīm [The First Born Son] created the 'Universe and Everything in it.'"
- Psalm 23:1 — "Yehōvah Ro'i [Messiah Pre-Incarnate My shepherd]; I shall not lack."
- Isaiah 7:14 — "Therefore the Lord-Adōnai (The Father)[Greatest Above All Things] himself shall give you a sign; Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and

bear a son, and shall call his name Emmanu'El (With Us is The Creator God)."

- John 1:1 — "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God-Theos, and the Word was God-Theos."
- Philippians 4:13 — "I can do all things through Moshiach [Messiah] which strengthens me."
- Jeremiah 29:11 — "For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD-Yehōvah (Messiah Pre-Incarnate), thoughts of peace, and not of evil, to give you an expected end."

Two more NMV commitments, from the publisher's own site (nmvbible.org):

- **A Messianic lens — the way the apostles read their Bibles.** The New Testament writers found Jesus everywhere in the Old Testament. The NMV translates with that same expectation: the Angel of Yehovah, the visible God on the mountain, the "I AM" of Exodus — rendered so the connection is unmistakable.
- **The Bible's unifying thread: the Jewish wedding.** From Genesis to Revelation, Scripture follows the pattern of an ancient Jewish wedding — the bride price, the betrothal, the bridegroom's departure, the sudden return. The NMV's translation choices keep that thread visible.

Honest limits. The published NMV is a proof of concept, not a full translation — that is the publisher's own description (nmvbible.org). The second edition now in development is the full translation built on the research behind *Jesus: The God of Abraham, Isaac & Jacob*. Buy the current edition for what it is: a working demonstration of the principles, with the full text free on YouVersion either way.

Editions (nmvbible.org, verified October 17, 2026): one-volume black cover and lion cover in print via Amazon; two-volume set; four-volume large

print; PDF ebook direct from tovrose.com at $17.99; the complete text free on YouVersion/Bible.com.

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4. The TLV: what it does differently

The Tree of Life Version began in May 2008 — originally a hoped-for Messianic children's Bible from a small group of rabbis' wives — and grew into a collaborative translation by 32 scholars. (tlvbiblesociety.org/about)

Its published distinctives, in the publisher's own words:

- "Messiah Yeshua" instead of "Jesus Christ"
- The Jewish book order for the Old Testament
- "The Greek sentence structure was restored to Hebrew sentence structure"
- "Faith turned into a verb instead of a noun, salvation became Yeshua, and peace became shalom"

Editions and prices (tlvbiblesociety.org shop, verified October 17, 2026): TLV Holy Scriptures Thinline Edition, leatherette, $47.00; TLV Holy Scriptures Thinline Edition, paperback, $29.00; Tree of Life Family Bible (TLV), $80.00; Messianic Jewish Family Bible (TLV), $85.00. Digital editions are also available through the publisher's app and major Bible platforms — check their site for the current list.

Best for: readers who want a committee translation rather than one translator's voice; families reading aloud; anyone who wants the Hebrew sentence feel in English.

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5. The CJB: what it does differently

The Complete Jewish Bible was translated by Dr. David H. Stern and published in its entirety in 1998 by Jewish New Testament Publications (an imprint of Messianic Jewish Publishers), Clarksville, Maryland.

- **New Testament:** Stern's original Jewish New Testament translation (first published 1989), translated from the ancient Greek.
- **Old Testament:** a paraphrase and revision of the public-domain 1917 Jewish Publication Society Tanakh — not a fresh translation from the Hebrew, which matters for how you weigh its Old Testament renderings.
- **Style:** Stern's stated purpose was "to restore God's Word to its original Jewish context and culture as well as be in easily read modern English." Semitic names for people and places, Hebrew book order for the Tanakh, and what Stern calls "Jewish English" — Hebrew and Yiddish expressions woven into modern English.
- **Companion:** Stern's verse-by-verse *Jewish New Testament Commentary* is sold separately and is the reason many students keep the CJB on the shelf even when they read daily from something else.
- **Digital:** listed as a digital module on Accordance ($14.90 at accordancebible.com at time of writing — third-party retailer, verify current pricing); also available in print through Messianic Jewish publishers and ChristianBook.

Best for: students who want one scholar's deeply consistent Jewish framing across both Testaments, and anyone pairing a translation with Stern's commentary.

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6. How to choose

- **Start with the question, not the brand.** Do you want to *study* (CJB + commentary, or NMV's bracketed identifications), *read aloud with family* (TLV), or *see the Messiah in the Tanakh* (NMV)?
- **Try before you buy.** The NMV's complete text is free on YouVersion. Read Psalm 23 and Isaiah 7 in all three before spending anything.
- **Read them side by side.** As one Amazon reviewer of the NMV put it (verbatim, verified purchase): "I whole heartedly recommend reading this and other translations side-by-side." No single translation ends the conversation.
- **Watch the Old Testament basis.** A fresh translation (NMV, TLV) and a paraphrase of a 1917 version (CJB's Tanakh) are different kinds of work. Neither is automatically better — but you should know which you are buying.

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7. Where to get them

- **NMV:** nmvbible.org — print via Amazon, $17.99 PDF ebook direct from tovrose.com, complete text free on YouVersion/Bible.com.
- **TLV:** tlvbiblesociety.org — Thinline and Family editions (see §4 for publisher-listed prices).
- **CJB:** Messianic Jewish Publishers and major Christian retailers including ChristianBook.

Affiliate disclosure: purchase links in the online companion to this guide are marked "Update Pending" until the publisher affiliate approvals clear. When live, they pay the publisher of this guide a commission at no extra cost to you. The NMV links support the NMV second-edition translation work.

About the author

Tov Rose translated the New Messianic Version Bible and has authored more than 30 books, including *Jesus: The God of Abraham, Isaac & Jacob* (2024), the research foundation for the NMV's second edition. He earned the ARRM Cares Award (2018) for coaching disabled business owners and was APSE Certified (2017–2020). This guide is published by C2R Marketing, LLC.

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